Basic spreadsheet tasks

We've talked about how
spreadsheets are great for organizing data and
performing calculations. Now, it's time to get our hands dirty and start building
a real spreadsheet. In this video, I'm going to
demonstrate some basic tasks we know data analysts
use spreadsheets for, including entering
and organizing data. We'll start with a
step-by-step process to show you some tools to organize
your data in a spreadsheet. Consider these steps the basics. You won't always have to use
them when working with a data set, but if your data is a bit
messy when you get it, these steps can help you
get it ready for analysis. Let's start by opening
a new spreadsheet. As a data analyst, you might not start with
a blank spreadsheet, but it's good to know how
to do it, just in case. Start by opening Excel, Google Sheets or whatever spreadsheet software
you're using, then select a new blank file. The first thing you'll
want to do when you open a new spreadsheet is give it
a title. Here's a pro tip. Make your title short, clear, and have it state exactly what the data in the
spreadsheet is about. Trust me, it'll make searching
for it a lot easier. Creating a folder on your
computer specifically for spreadsheets and related files can also make it
easier to find them. For this spreadsheet, it's
already saved in our drive. So we'll open our File
menu to click Move. Then we'll create a new folder, name it "Population Data," and move the
spreadsheet there. Our spreadsheet now
has a new home. This will save you a lot of unnecessary clicks and headaches when you look
for this file. There's a few different
ways data analysts get data they work with. Depending on the job, you might use data
from an open source, you might be given
data to work with or you might be asked
to find your own data. You'll experience all of
these later in the program. There's a lot of open
data sources online, where data is made
available to the public. For example, we'll use
data from worldbank.org, that's already in

the spreadsheet. The data shows the population of Latin America and Caribbean countries from 2010-2019. Let's open this spreadsheet. Time to get the data ready for analysis. We'll start by selecting the whole sheet and making our columns wider by dragging the boundary of one of the columns. This will help us see the data clearly, then we can adjust any individual columns that need it. You can make columns wider in other ways as well, but this will work for now. The first row of the spreadsheet is for data attributes or variables. It's basically labeling the type of data in each column. Let's make the attributes stand out from the rest of the rows by selecting it and filling it with color. We'll also make the labels bold. If we want to add another data attribute between two of the other attributes, we can always add a new column. Just click on any cell within a column and use the Insert menu to add a new one. It will appear next to the column you originally clicked, pretty simple. Deleting a column is just as simple. To delete, right-click in a cell in the column you want to get rid of. The steps we're showing may be different depending on the spreadsheet program you're using, but should be pretty similar. Let's add one more thing to our data table: borders. This can help you see each piece of data more clearly. To add borders start by clicking the Select All button at the top left corner of your spreadsheet. This is like a magic button because you can click it whenever you need to make changes to every cell in your spreadsheet. Then click the Border button in the menu, and choose the type of borders you want. To keep our spreadsheets uniform, we'll choose borders for all cells. Just like that, we've gone from raw to refined. Now our spreadsheet is filled with data and it's nice to look at too. Using these organization tools before you analyze can help you focus on the data once you start your analysis. Now that we've gone over some ways spreadsheets can be used to organize data, you're ready to start working on them yourself. Later you'll learn more about spreadsheets, including some common errors and how to fix them.